

Concept of disease and illness

- According to Leon Eisenberg: patients suffer 'illnesses'; physicians diagnose and treat 'disease' . . . illnesses are **experiences** of disvalued changes in states of being and social function: diseases are **abnormalities** in the structure and function of body organs and systems (curing vs. managing)
- Disease:
 - 'Objective' quality (pathological condition)
 - Independent of social behaviour
- Illness:
 - Subjective experiences of bodily disorder and feelings of pain and discomfort
 - 'Subjective unwellness'
- Advantages of distinguishing these two:
 - It indicates recognition of the social aspects of ill health
 - Not fixed concepts...concept of normalcy (embarrassment)
 - Better understanding of individual and societal responses to ill health

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Four definitions of health:

- ▣ ***Absence of clinically ascertainable disease:***

- ▣ ***Absence of illness:***

- ▣ ***Complete well-being:***

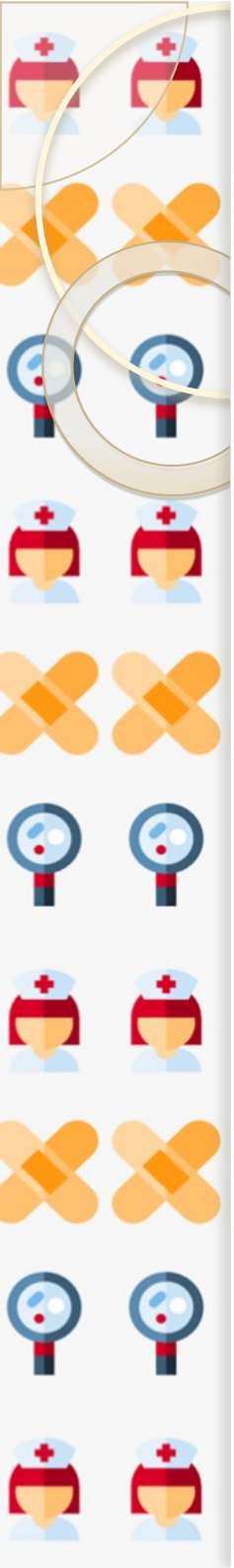
- ▣ ***Normative expectations:***

- ▣ The aim...of functional capacity is to identify the extent to which individuals can **perform the social roles expected of them.**

- ▣ Scales are used for this purpose

History of Health and Healing

- The roots are found in ancient civilisation of **Greece and Rome** (approx. 3000 years ago)
- But, the history can even be traced back to **Neolithic period** (5000 years ago)
- Ex. Trepanation/trepanning to craniotomy
- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Jcs-EceXHsQ>
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□ *Neolithic revolution*

- Fertile crescent of middle east demonstrates first instance of the shift
- **Fixed-place lifestyle** had implication for health
- **Domestication of wild animals...**
- The process known as **Zoonosis**...humans' immunity
- Another change was that disease became **Endemic**
- What emerges here...the way humans go about being social

□ *Industrial revolution*

- Shift from small-scale craft to large-scale homogenized factory...reshaped society in many ways (influencing health)

MEDICINE AS SOCIAL CONTROL

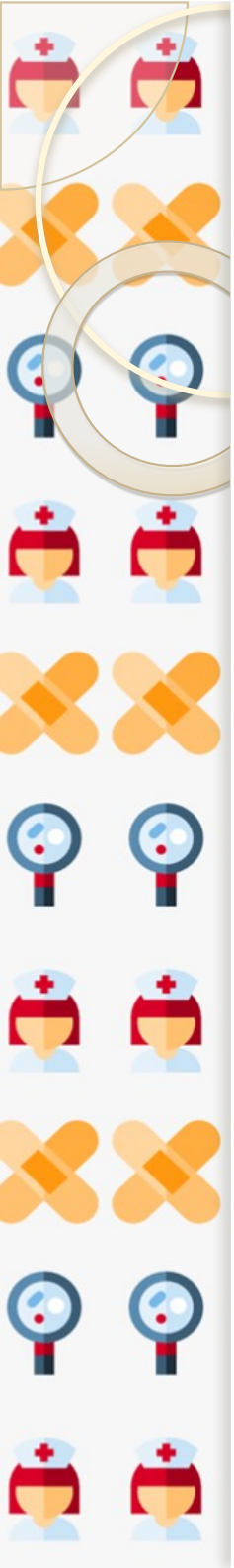
- The word 'medicine'...sociologists refer to medicine as an **institution**...social structures that meet basic human needs
- Power of medicine as an institution has **grown over the past century.**
- Medicine as an institution of **social control**...social group—norms—conform
- Doctors as social control agents

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Creating Illness: Medicalization

- The **process** through which a condition or behavior becomes defined as a **medical problem** requiring a **medical solution** is known as medicalization
- It also means how the definition of an illness is **broadened**...definition of osteoporosis
- For medicalization to occur...one or more organized **social groups** with a **vested interest** in medicalization and **sufficient power** to convince others to accept their new definition of the situation.
- 20th century and Pediatricians...(ADHD)

□ *Case study: medicalising ADHD*

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Unintended consequences of Medicalization

□ First:

- Doctors become the only experts considered appropriate
power of doctors increases and power of other social authorities decreases
- Doctors answer the questions...It expands the range of life experiences under medical control.

□ Second:

- Once a condition is medicalized, medical treatment may seem the only **logical response** to it

□ Third:

- Medicalization allowed governments to **depoliticize** the situation

□ Fourth:

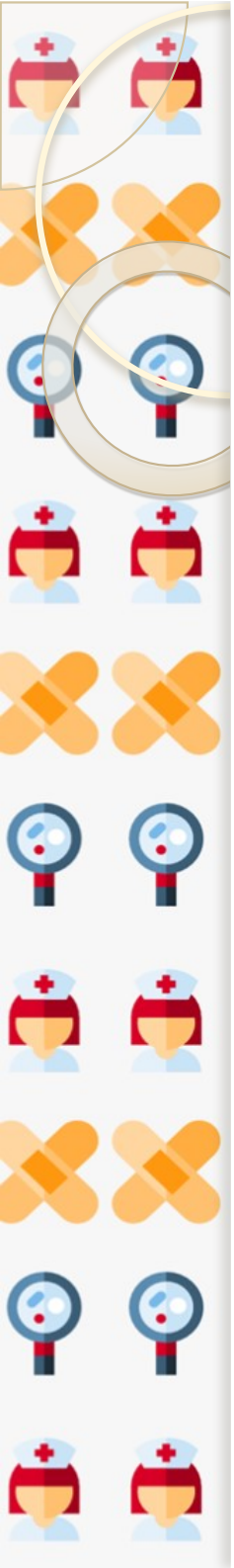
- Medicalization can **justify involuntary treatment**

Medicalization and the “Potentially Ill”

- They are individuals identified as having an **above-average risk** of illness
- They learn about gene (guaranteed to cause a fatal disease) or other conditions (cholesterol to increase health risk)
- The numbers of such individuals continues to increase as corporations develop **more tests for risk factors** and as **doctors** (often reimbursed per test) **adopt such tests**.
- Benefits of identifying and managing risks vs. psychological distress

SOCIAL DETERMINANTS OF HEALTH

- The primary determinants of the health of people and of the distribution of diseases within society are embedded in the **social structure of society**.
- ***Physical environment***: The presence of harmful substances in the **workplace** (e.g., hydrocarbons in coal), or in the **home** (e.g., lead paint), or in the **neighborhood** (e.g., the proximity to a landfill) serves as a pathway to ill health.
- ***Social environment (and psychological response)***: Some persons live in a **more stressful social environment** than others, and some have greater access to **supportive social relationships**.
- ***Differential susceptibility***: The opportunities that individuals have for occupational success have been shown to be **partially influenced by physical traits**

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- ▣ **Individual lifestyle:** Some persons live a healthier lifestyle than others, which is further influenced by the social factors (ex. Safe neighborhood)
 - ▣ **Differential access to/response to health care services:** In differential propensity to use services, and in differential benefit of services received.
 - ▣ **Reverse causality:** One's health status influences position in the social structure rather than the other way around (ex. Relationship between income and sickness)